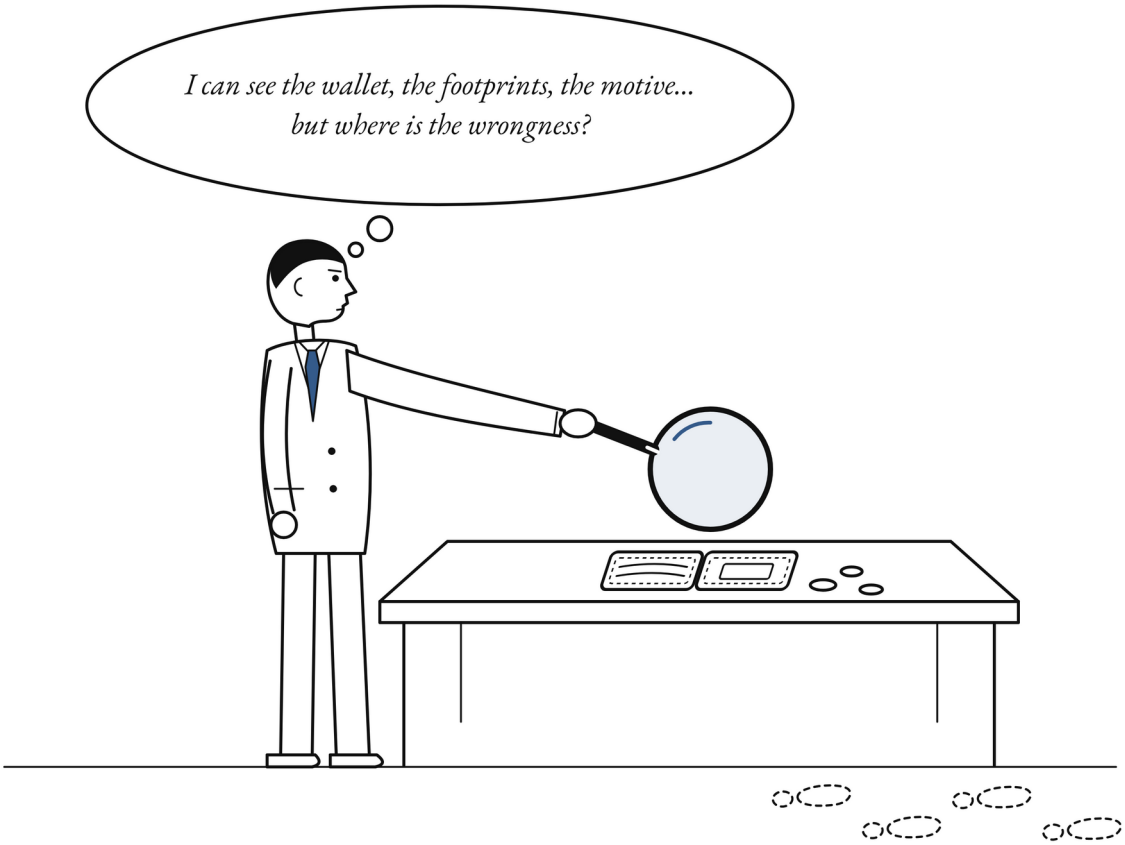
Metaethics

Upper Sixth Philosophy • OCR Religious Studies A Level



Metaethics Booklet

Upper Sixth Philosophy • OCR Religious Studies A Level

Table of Contents

How to Use This Booklet....3

Glossary....5

Part I Natural facts and moral value....7

1 Naturalism and the meaning of good....7

2 Hume on moral feeling and the move from is to ought....10

Part II Intuition and moral knowledge....14

3 Moore and Ross: indefinable good, self-evident principles....14

Part III Moral language and attitudes....18

4 Ayer and the expression of feeling....18

5 Stevenson and moral disagreement....21

6 Hare and the logic of prescription....25

Part IV Challenges to moral truth....28

7 Mackie and the challenge to moral realism....28

Essay 1 Ethical meaning....32

Essay 2 Objective moral facts....35

Essay 3 Self-evident goodness....38

Essay 4 Explaining good....42

Readings and questions on moral meaning, moral truth and moral knowledge. Core approaches: naturalism, intuitionism and emotivism.

How to Use This Booklet

This booklet asks what moral judgements mean, whether they can be true, and how moral knowledge might be possible. Read each introduction and extract before its questions. Underline the main claim and supporting reasons, then formulate an objection. Write answers in your notes and use the margins for annotations.

Comprehension establishes what a thinker claims. **Analysis** reconstructs an argument and tests its assumptions. **Synthesis** connects positions without erasing their differences. **Evaluation** weighs an objection against the best reply and reaches a defended judgement. These are learning tasks, not separate examination sections.

Each OCR essay carries 40 marks: AO1 knowledge and understanding 16; AO2 analysis and evaluation 24. H573/02 allows two hours for three essays chosen from four. The AO tags show each study task's emphasis. Each essay plan is followed by an argument map: solid arrows show which reasons support each thesis, and dashed arrows show which reason each counter-argument challenges and which objection each reply answers. Read down each chain, then connect both chains in a sustained judgement about the question.

The OCR focus

The specification names three meta-ethical theories and defines each. Naturalism is 'the belief that values can be defined in terms of some natural property in the world' (Topics 1 and 2). Intuitionism is 'the belief that basic moral truths are indefinable but self-evident', applied to the term good (Topic 3). Emotivism is 'the belief that ethical terms evince approval or disapproval', applied to relativism (Topics 4 and 5). The definition of intuitionism joins a claim about meaning ('indefinable') to a claim about knowledge ('self-evident').

The specification also sets debates for discussion: whether what is meant by the word 'good' is the defining question in the study of ethics; whether ethical terms such as good, bad, right and wrong 'have an objective factual basis that makes them true or false in describing something', 'reflect only what is in the mind of the person using such terms', and 'can be said to be meaningful or meaningless'; and whether, 'from a common sense approach, people just know within themselves

what is good, bad, right and wrong'. Its suggested reading is Moore's *Principia Ethica* (Topics 1 and 3), Ayer's *Language, Truth and Logic* (Topic 4) and Mackie's *Ethics: Inventing Right and Wrong* (Topic 7). Hume, Ross, Stevenson, Hare and Miller are extensions. Past examination questions on this topic name no thinker; they ask about the three theories and about the terms good, bad, right and wrong.

Four questions to keep separate

Meaning: Does a moral judgement state a claim, express an attitude, or prescribe an action?

Reality: Are there moral facts independent of what anyone approves?

Knowledge: If moral claims can be true, what would justify believing them?

Motivation: How does judging an action right connect with wanting or choosing to do it?

Cognitivism concerns truth-aptness; realism concerns moral reality. They are not synonyms. Similarly, intuitionism is about moral knowledge, whereas non-naturalism concerns what moral properties are. Keep these distinctions visible throughout your reading.

Sources: Alexander Miller, Contemporary Metaethics: An Introduction, 2nd edition (Polity, 2013), plus primary readings from Ayer and Stevenson in Topics 4–5. References identify supplied PDF pages; Stevenson's printed pages are also given. Line breaks are reset and Miller's endnote markers omitted; wording is unchanged. Commentary and tasks are original. The four final essay plans address genuine OCR questions, linked to their papers; they are possible approaches, not official model answers. Readings by Moore, Hume, Ross, Hare and Mackie are from Russ Shafer-Landau (ed.), Ethical Theory: An Anthology, 2nd edition (Wiley-Blackwell, 2013).

Glossary

Cognitivism: The view that moral judgements are truth-apt: like 'The bell has rung', they state beliefs that can be true or false. Cognitivism does not say that any moral judgement is true. Mackie is a cognitivist who holds that ordinary moral judgements, such as 'Murder is wrong', are false. Topics 1, 4 and 7.

Error theory: Mackie's view that ordinary moral judgements claim to describe objective values, requirements that hold whatever anyone wants, but that no such values exist, so these claims are false. Compare 'The school ghost slammed the door': it is meaningful, but false, because nothing answers to it. Topic 7.

Frege–Geach problem: Named after Gottlob Frege and Peter Geach. The difficulty, for emotivism and for Hare, of explaining what moral words mean in unasserted contexts, such as 'If lying is wrong, then encouraging lying is wrong', which condemns nothing, and why arguments that use them are valid. Topic 6.

Naturalistic fallacy: Moore's name for the mistake of identifying goodness with some other property, as in 'good just means pleasant' or 'good just means what most people approve of'. Moore holds that it is the same mistake whether the other property is natural or not. Topics 1 and 3.

Prescription: In Hare's sense, an utterance that tells someone what to do, as a command does: 'Hand in your homework on Friday.' Hare holds that moral judgements are prescriptions that must be universalisable: whoever makes one must apply it to every relevantly similar case. Topic 6.

Realism: Moral realism is the view that some moral judgements are true because there are moral facts that do not depend on anyone's approval of them, or on what anyone feels about them. 'Bullying is wrong' would then be true whatever the bully or the school thinks. Moore and most naturalists are realists; Mackie denies that such facts exist. Topics 1, 3 and 7.

Reductive: A reductive account holds that one thing is nothing over and above another. A reductive naturalist holds that goodness just is some natural property, for example that good = pleasure, as water just is H_2O. Moore's open-question argument targets such accounts; Topic 1 gives a naturalist reply. Topic 1.

Simple: In Moore's sense, having no parts. A complex notion such as 'horse' can be defined by listing its parts and how they fit together; a simple notion such as 'yellow' cannot, and can only be recognised. Moore holds that good is simple, and therefore indefinable. Topic 3.

Truth-aptness: Being capable of being true or false. 'Homework is due on Friday' is truth-apt; 'Hand in your homework!' and 'Hooray for Friday!' are not. Cognitivists hold that moral judgements are truth-apt; Ayer denies it. Topics 1 and 4.

Truth-conditions: The circumstances in which a sentence would be true: 'The bell has rung' is true if and only if the bell has rung. A naturalist holds that the truth-conditions of moral judgements concern natural facts, such as facts about pleasure. Topic 1.

Validity: An argument is valid when its conclusion must be true if its premises are true. Validity concerns form, not truth: 'All pupils are robots; Sam is a pupil; so Sam is a robot' is valid, although its first premise is false. Topics 1, 2 and 6.

Weakness of will: Acting against one's own judgement of what one ought to do, as when a pupil judges that she ought to revise tonight but watches television instead. It troubles views, such as Hare's, on which sincerely judging 'I ought' commits one to acting. Topic 6.

Part I Natural facts and moral value

1 Naturalism and the meaning of good

Introduction

The specification defines naturalism as 'the belief that values can be defined in terms of some natural property in the world'. Our main example is ethical hedonism: pleasure is the only thing intrinsically good, that is, good for its own sake, and pain the only thing intrinsically bad. A reductive naturalist holds that goodness is nothing over and above some natural property; for the hedonist, that property is pleasure: good = pleasure. Miller explains what makes a property natural. Moore then asks whether 'good' can mean 'pleasant'. Other naturalists appeal instead to human flourishing.

The text

Miller, Contemporary Metaethics (2013), §1.3, supplied PDF pp. 26–27. Includes a quotation from Moore.

> A strong cognitivist theory is one which holds that moral judgements (a) are apt for evaluation in terms of truth and falsity, and (b) can be the upshot of cognitively accessing the facts which render them true. Strong cognitivist theories can be either naturalist or non-naturalist. According to a naturalist, a moral judgement is rendered true or false by a natural state of affairs, and it is this natural state of affairs to which a true moral judgement affords us access. But what is a natural state of affairs? In this book I will follow G. E. Moore's characterization:
>
> > By nature then I do mean and have meant that which is the subject matter of the natural sciences, and also of psychology. (Moore 1903: 92)

Moore reading The open question

G. E. Moore, Principia Ethica (1903), §13; in Russ Shafer-Landau (ed.), Ethical Theory: An Anthology, 2nd edition (2013), p. 53.

> And the same consideration is sufficient to dismiss the hypothesis that "good" has no meaning whatsoever. ... But whoever will attentively consider with himself what is actually before his mind when he asks the question "Is pleasure (or whatever it may be) after all good?" can easily satisfy himself that he is not merely wondering whether pleasure is pleasant. And if he will try this experiment with each suggested definition in succession, he may become expert enough to recognize that in every case he has before his mind a unique object, with regard to the connection of which with any other object, a distinct question may be asked. Every one does in fact understand the question "Is this good?" When he thinks of it, his state of mind is different from what it would be, were he asked "Is this pleasant, or desired, or approved?" It has a distinct meaning for him, even though he may not recognize in what respect it is distinct.

Reading the argument

Miller defines strong cognitivism: moral judgements are truth-apt, capable of being true or false, and we can know the facts that make them true. For a naturalist, their truth-conditions, the circumstances that would make them true, are natural. Miller adopts Moore's test of the natural, which ends 'and also of psychology'. That clause is the hinge: pleasure is psychological, so identifying goodness with pleasure is naturalist.

Moore's argument, set out validly:

1. If 'good' meant 'pleasant', 'Is pleasure good?' would ask the same as 'Is pleasure pleasant?'
2. 'Is pleasure pleasant?' is closed: anyone who understands it can answer 'yes' at once.
3. So, if 'good' meant 'pleasant', 'Is pleasure good?' would be closed too.
4. But it is open: understanding it leaves the answer unsettled. Whoever asks it is 'not merely wondering whether pleasure is pleasant'.
5. So 'good' does not mean 'pleasant'.

A naturalist replies that two expressions can name one property without sharing a meaning: 'water' and 'H_2O' differ in meaning but name one substance. The specification's definition of naturalism survives if its 'defined' says what goodness is, not what 'good' means. Moral claims would then have an 'objective factual basis' open to psychology.

Questions for study

Comprehension *(AO1)*

1. Using Miller's extract, explain what makes a moral theory naturalist, and why a theory that identifies goodness with pleasure counts as one.
2. Using Moore's reading, explain why 'Is pleasure good?' is an open question when 'Is pleasure pleasant?' is not, and what Moore concludes from the difference.

Analysis *(AO1 and AO2)*

1. Analyse which sense of 'defined' Moore's open-question argument must assume if it is to refute the view that values can be 'defined in terms of some natural property in the world'.

Synthesis *(AO1 and AO2)*

1. Synthesise Miller's account of naturalism with Moore's reading, showing what Moore can share with the naturalist about moral judgements and where they divide.

Evaluation *(AO2)*

1. Critically evaluate the claim that identifying goodness with pleasure gives moral judgements an 'objective factual basis that makes them true or false in describing something'.
2. Critically evaluate the claim that the question of what goodness is, rather than what is meant by the word 'good', is 'the defining question in the study of ethics'.

Examination style essay *(AO1 16 marks and AO2 24 marks)*

> Assess the view that 'good' can be 'defined in terms of some natural property in the world'. [40]

2 Hume on moral feeling and the move from is to ought

Introduction

David Hume (1711–1776) asks whether moral distinctions are discovered by reason. In the first reading he examines a wilful murder and finds the vice not in the action but in the observer's feeling. This anticipates emotivism. In the second reading he notices writers on morality sliding from what is the case to what ought to be, and asks how an 'ought' could follow from an 'is'. This challenges naturalism, which defines values by natural properties. The title of Hume's section states his conclusion: 'Moral Distinctions Not Derived from Reason'.

The text

David Hume, A Treatise of Human Nature (1739–40), Book III, Part I, Section I; in Russ Shafer-Landau (ed.), Ethical Theory: An Anthology, 2nd edition (2013), p. 14.

> But can there be any difficulty in proving that vice and virtue are not matters of fact, whose existence we can infer by reason? Take any action allowed to be vicious; wilful murder, for instance. Examine it in all lights, and see if you can find that matter of fact, or real existence, which you call *vice*. In whichever way you take it, you find only certain passions, motives, volitions, and thoughts. There is no other matter of fact in the case. The vice entirely escapes you, as long as you consider the object. You never can find it, till you turn your reflection into your own breast, and find a sentiment of disapprobation, which arises in you, towards this action. Here is a matter of fact; but it is the object of feeling, not of reason. It lies in yourself, not in the object. So that when you pronounce any action or character to be vicious, you mean nothing, but that from the constitution of your nature you have a feeling or sentiment of blame from the contemplation of it.

Hume reading 2 Is and ought

Hume, A Treatise of Human Nature (1739–40), Book III, Part I, Section I; in Shafer-Landau (ed.), Ethical Theory: An Anthology (2013), p. 14.

> I cannot forbear adding to these reasonings an observation, which may, perhaps, be found of some importance. In every system of morality which I have hitherto met with, I have always remarked, that the author proceeds for some time in the ordinary way of reasoning, and establishes the being of a God, or makes observations concerning human affairs; when of a sudden I am surprised to find, that instead of the usual copulations of propositions, *is*, and *is not*, I meet with no proposition that is not connected with an *ought*, or an *ought not*. This change is imperceptible; but is, however, of the last consequence. For as this *ought*, or *ought not*, expresses some new relation or affirmation, it is necessary that it should be observed and explained; and at the same time that a reason should be given, for what seems altogether inconceivable, how this new relation can be a deduction from others, which are entirely different from it. But as authors do not commonly use this precaution, I shall presume to recommend it to the readers; and am persuaded, that this small attention would subvert all the vulgar systems of morality, and let us see that the distinction of vice and virtue is not founded merely on the relations of objects, nor is perceived by reason.

Reading the argument

In the first reading Hume examines a 'wilful murder' and finds only 'passions, motives, volitions, and thoughts' ('volitions' are acts of will). The vice appears only when the observer looks inward and finds 'a sentiment of disapprobation', a feeling of disapproval: it 'lies in yourself, not in the object'. The only fact found concerns the observer. Moral terms seem to 'reflect only what is in the mind of the person using such terms', without an 'objective factual basis'.

The second reading adds that 'ought' 'expresses some new relation', so Hume asks how it can be 'a deduction' from 'is' premises 'entirely different from it'. A deduction is a valid inference: if its premises are true, its conclusion must be. 'The school has always done this, so it ought to continue' is

not valid until we add 'Traditions ought to continue'. Hume concludes that moral distinctions are not 'perceived by reason'.

This challenges naturalism: if 'good' were definable by a natural property, natural facts alone would yield moral conclusions. Hume also anticipates emotivism, with a difference: 'you mean nothing, but that … you have a feeling' sounds like reporting a feeling, which Ayer distinguishes from expressing one (Topic 4).

Questions for study

Comprehension *(AO1)*

1. Using Hume's first reading, explain why Hume concludes that the vice of a wilful murder 'lies in yourself, not in the object'.
2. Using Hume's second reading, explain what Hume asks of writers who move from 'is' to 'ought', and why he thinks the move needs a reason.

Analysis *(AO1 and AO2)*

1. Analyse whether the claim that values can be 'defined in terms of some natural property in the world' could supply the premise needed to make an inference from 'is' to 'ought' valid.
2. Analyse what Hume's first reading must assume if it is to show that ethical terms 'reflect only what is in the mind of the person using such terms'.

Synthesis *(AO1 and AO2)*

1. Synthesise Hume's first reading with Miller's account of naturalism in Topic 1, showing in what sense Hume's 'matter of fact' about vice is natural.

Evaluation *(AO2)*

1. Critically evaluate the claim that, because no 'ought' can be deduced from an 'is', ethical terms cannot have an 'objective factual basis'.
2. Critically evaluate the claim that, if moral distinctions are felt rather than 'perceived by reason', people 'just know within themselves' what is wrong.

Examination style essay *(AO1 16 marks and AO2 24 marks)*

Evaluate the view that ethical terms such as good, bad, right and wrong 'reflect only what is in the mind of the person using such terms'. [40]

Part II Intuition and moral knowledge

3 Moore and Ross: indefinable good, self-evident principles

Introduction

The specification defines intuitionism as 'the belief that basic moral truths are indefinable but self-evident', and asks how it applies to the term good. The first reading gives G. E. Moore's case for the first half: 'good' cannot be defined. The second gives W. D. Ross's account of the second half: some basic moral principles are evident to a mature mind without proof. Notice that Ross's examples concern what is right, not what is good. As you read, ask how self-evidence differs from a strong feeling of certainty.

The text

G. E. Moore, Principia Ethica (1903), §§6, 7, 10; in Russ Shafer-Landau (ed.), Ethical Theory: An Anthology, 2nd edition (2013), pp. 48–50.

> What, then, is good? How is good to be defined? Now, it may be thought that this is a verbal question. A definition does indeed often mean the expressing of one word's meaning in other words. But this is not the sort of definition I am asking for. Such a definition can never be of ultimate importance in any study except lexicography. ... My business is solely with that object or idea, which I hold, rightly or wrongly, that the word is generally used to stand for. What I want to discover is the nature of that object or idea, and about this I am extremely anxious to arrive at an agreement. But, if we understand the question in this sense, my answer to it may seem a very disappointing one. If I am asked "What is good?" my answer is that good is good, and that is the end of the matter. Or if I am asked "How is good to be defined?" my answer is that it cannot be defined, and that is all I have to say about it. ... My point is that "good" is a simple notion, just as "yellow" is a simple notion; that, just as you cannot, by any manner of means, explain to any one who does not already know it, what yellow is, so you cannot explain what good is. ... "Good," then, if we mean by it that quality which we assert to belong to a thing, when we say that the thing is good,

> is incapable of any definition, in the most important sense of that word. The most important sense of "definition" is that in which a definition states what are the parts which invariably compose a certain whole; and in this sense "good" has no definition because it is simple and has no parts.

Ross reading Self-evident duties

W. D. Ross, The Right and the Good (1930), 'What Makes Right Acts Right?'; in Russ Shafer-Landau (ed.), Ethical Theory: An Anthology, 2nd edition (2013), p. 759.

> That an act, qua fulfilling a promise, or qua effecting a just distribution of good, or qua returning services rendered, or qua promoting the good of others, or qua promoting the virtue or insight of the agent, is prima facie right, is self-evident; not in the sense that it is evident from the beginning of our lives, or as soon as we attend to the proposition for the first time, but in the sense that when we have reached sufficient mental maturity and have given sufficient attention to the proposition it is evident without any need of proof, or of evidence beyond itself. It is self-evident just as a mathematical axiom, or the validity of a form of inference, is evident. The moral order expressed in these propositions is just as much part of the fundamental nature of the universe (and, we may add, of any possible universe in which there were moral agents at all) as is the spatial or numerical structure expressed in the axioms of geometry or arithmetic. ... Our judgements about our actual duty in concrete situations have none of the certainty that attaches to our recognition of the general principles of duty.

Reading the argument

Moore's question is not verbal: a verbal definition is of 'ultimate importance' only in 'lexicography'; he wants 'the nature of that object or idea'. The defining question, for Moore, is what good is. In 'the most important sense', a definition states the parts of a whole; good, like yellow, is 'simple' and 'has no parts', so it can be recognised but not defined. Treating good as identical with another property is what Moore calls the 'naturalistic fallacy' (Moore, §10). Indefinable does not mean meaningless, and we can still ask which things are good.

For Ross, 'prima facie right' means that an act would be our duty if it had no other morally significant feature; 'qua' means 'in so far as it is'. Such principles are 'self-evident' in a precise sense: evident 'without any need of proof' once we reach 'sufficient mental maturity' and attend to them, like a mathematical axiom. The certainty covers principles only: whether to keep a promise or help an injured pupil may stay uncertain.

The readings supply the specification's definition: Moore gives 'indefinable', Ross 'self-evident'. Ross also answers whether people 'just know within themselves' what is right: much of 'what we think' we 'do not think but know' (Ross, p. 761), though only after mature reflection.

Questions for study

Comprehension *(AO1)*

1. Using Moore's extract, explain why the comparison with yellow leads Moore to hold that good cannot be defined.
2. Using Ross's reading, explain in what sense Ross calls prima facie principles 'self-evident', and why this certainty does not extend to our actual duty in particular situations.

Analysis *(AO1 and AO2)*

1. Analyse the inference from the claim that good is indefinable to the conclusion that 'basic moral truths' are 'self-evident', identifying the further premise it needs.
2. Analyse whether Ross's reading, whose self-evident principles concern what is right, supports applying intuitionism to 'the term good'.

Synthesis *(AO1 and AO2)*

1. Synthesise Moore's comparison of good with yellow and Ross's comparison of moral principles with mathematical axioms, showing what kind of moral knowledge each suggests.

Evaluation *(AO2)*

1. Critically evaluate whether Ross's account of self-evidence supports the view that people 'just know within themselves' what is right.
2. Critically evaluate the claim that, if 'good' cannot be defined, it must be 'meaningless'.

Examination style essay *(AO1 16 marks and AO2 24 marks)*

'From a common sense approach, people just know within themselves what is good, bad, right and wrong.' Discuss. [40]

Part III Moral language and attitudes

4 Ayer and the expression of feeling

Introduction

A. J. Ayer (1910–1989) approaches ethics through a theory of meaning. In *Language, Truth and Logic* he argues that factual claims must be answerable to possible experience, while analytic truths depend on logic or meaning. The purely evaluative content of ethical judgements, he contends, fits neither category. Their function must therefore be understood differently. Emotivism explains them as expressions of approval or disapproval which may also influence others. The provocative conclusion is that a moral utterance can matter greatly in human life without stating a moral fact. Understanding that distinction is essential before deciding whether the theory succeeds.

The text

Miller, Contemporary Metaethics (2013), §3.4, supplied PDF p. 79.

> According to emotivism, when I judge that murder is wrong I am not saying anything: I am rather expressing or evincing my disapproval. This is why versions of non-cognitivism are sometimes called expressivism. According to emotivism, when I judge that murder is wrong, I am no more saying or reporting that I disapprove of murder than I say or report that I am in pain when I cry '@*%$!' after standing on a nail. My utterance of '@*%$!' is not a report, and so a fortiori not a report that I am in pain: it is an expression of pain, not a saying about it.

Ayer reading 1 The ethical symbol

A. J. Ayer, Language, Truth and Logic (Penguin Books, 2001), ch. 6, "Critique of Ethics and Theology"; supplied PDF p. 106.

> The presence of an ethical symbol in a proposition adds nothing to its factual content. Thus if I say to someone, 'You acted wrongly in stealing that money,' I am not stating anything more than if I had simply said, 'You stole that money.' In adding

that this action is wrong I am not making any further statement about it. I am simply evincing my moral disapproval of it. It is as if I had said, 'You stole that money,' in a peculiar tone of horror, or written it with the addition of some special exclamation marks.

Ayer reading 2 Arousing feeling and prompting action

Ayer, Language, Truth and Logic (2001), ch. 6, supplied PDF p. 107.

It is worth mentioning that ethical terms do not serve only to express feeling. They are calculated also to arouse feeling, and so to stimulate action. Indeed some of them are used in such a way as to give the sentences in which they occur the effect of commands. Thus the sentence 'It is your duty to tell the truth' may be regarded both as the expression of a certain sort of ethical feeling about truthfulness and as the expression of the command 'Tell the truth.' The sentence 'You ought to tell the truth' also involves the command 'Tell the truth', but here the tone of the command is less emphatic. In the sentence 'It is good to tell the truth' the command has become little more than a suggestion.

Reading the argument

The specification defines emotivism as 'the belief that ethical terms evince approval or disapproval'; to 'evince' is to express, and Miller's 'a fortiori' means 'all the more'. In Ayer's first reading, 'wrongly' adds disapproval, not factual meaning. Expressing disapproval also differs from reporting 'I disapprove', a psychological claim that could be true or false.

Ayer relies on 'the principle that a synthetic proposition is significant only if it is empirically verifiable' (Ayer, ch. 6): factual claims need possible observational tests. The ethical element has none, so it states nothing. A critic can ask whether the principle passes its own test. The second reading adds that ethical terms also arouse feeling; Stevenson develops this.

The specification asks how emotivism applies to relativism. If one person calls stealing wrong and another calls it right, each merely expresses feeling: one 'cannot, strictly speaking, contradict' the other, and there is 'no sense in asking which of us is in the right' (Ayer, ch. 6). Values may then vary

between individuals and societies, with no fact to decide between them. Yet Ayer does not say that moral statements are true for one culture and false for another: they are neither true nor false.

Questions for study

Comprehension *(AO1)*

1. Using Miller's extract, explain why, for the emotivist, judging that murder is wrong is not a report that one disapproves of murder.
2. Using Ayer's first reading, explain why, if one person calls stealing wrong and another calls it right, neither contradicts the other.

Analysis *(AO1 and AO2)*

1. Analyse how well Miller's comparison between a moral judgement and a cry of pain illustrates the view that ethical terms 'evince approval or disapproval'.
2. Analyse whether emotivism holds that ethical terms 'reflect only what is in the mind of the person using such terms', distinguishing reporting a feeling from expressing one.

Synthesis *(AO1 and AO2)*

1. Synthesise Moore's and Ayer's accounts of what an ethical word adds to a sentence, showing where they agree and where they divide.

Evaluation *(AO2)*

1. Critically evaluate the claim that, if emotivism leads to 'relativism', there is no rational way to criticise another society's moral attitudes.
2. Critically evaluate the claim that, if the verification principle fails its own test, the case for treating ethical terms as 'meaningless' collapses.

Examination style essay *(AO1 16 marks and AO2 24 marks)*

> Critically assess the view that 'emotivism' leads to 'relativism'. [40]

5 Stevenson and moral disagreement

Introduction

Suppose two governors agree that a school meals scheme would reduce hunger, improve concentration and cost a particular amount. One calls the scheme good; the other opposes it. Have they overlooked a fact, or reached a moral disagreement? Stevenson develops emotivism by distinguishing disagreement in belief from disagreement in interest, often called disagreement in attitude. Read his 1937 examples alongside Miller's later discussion. Ask whether influencing someone's attitudes also amounts to justifying a moral judgement.

The text

Miller, Contemporary Metaethics (2013), §3.6, supplied PDF p. 98. Miller quotes Peter Kivy.

> We can move towards an analogous argument against Ayer's emotivism by focusing upon the fact that a clear function of moral discourse is to convince others, specifically to motivate others to act in certain ways. As Peter Kivy has observed, this feature of moral discourse is well captured in the version of emotivism developed by Charles Stevenson:
>
> > The direct purpose of ethical argumentation is implied in the exhortative moment of moral value terms: what the late Charles L. Stevenson called their 'quasi-imperative' part. These terms evince our approval; but they also urge our attitudes upon others. 'I approve; do so as well', was Stevenson's rough analysis of 'good'. (Kivy 1992: 311; see also Stevenson 1937 and 1944)

Stevenson reading 1 Moral language directs interests

C. L. Stevenson, "The Emotive Meaning of Ethical Terms", Mind 46, no. 181 (1937), pp. 14–31, §II; printed p. 19; supplied PDF p. 7.

> For instance: When you tell a man that he oughtn't to steal, your object isn't merely to let him know that people disapprove of stealing. You are attempting, rather, to get *him* to disapprove of it. Your ethical judgment has a quasi-imperative force which,

> operating through suggestion, and intensified by your tone of voice, readily permits you to begin to *influence*, to *modify*, his interests. If in the end you do not succeed in getting *him* to disapprove of stealing, you will feel that you've failed to convince him that stealing is wrong. You will continue to feel this, even though he fully acknowledges that you disapprove of it, and that almost everyone else does.

Stevenson reading 2 Facts and ethical agreement

C. L. Stevenson, "The Emotive Meaning of Ethical Terms", Mind 46, no. 181 (1937), pp. 14–31, §V; printed p. 29; supplied PDF p. 17.

> Is the empirical method *sufficient* for attaining ethical agreement? Clearly not. For empirical knowledge resolves disagreement in interest only to the extent that such disagreement is rooted in disagreement in belief. Not all disagreement in interest is of this sort. For instance: A is of a sympathetic nature, and B isn't. They are arguing about whether a public dole would be good. Suppose that they discovered all the consequences of the dole. Isn't it possible, even so, that A will say that it's good, and B that it's bad ? The disagreement in interest may arise not from limited factual knowledge, but simply from A's sympathy and B's coldness.

Reading the argument

A 'quasi-imperative' force is command-like: the judgement works 'through suggestion' on the hearer's interests. Kivy's 'I approve; do so as well' abbreviates Stevenson's own formula: in 1937 he says that 'This is good' has 'something like the meaning' of 'I *do* like this; do so as well', and adds at once, 'But this is certainly not accurate' (Stevenson, §IV). He also allows 'some element of description' (Stevenson, §II).

Miller turns this persuasive function against Ayer's emotivism. Yet Ayer's second reading (Topic 4) calls ethical terms 'calculated also to arouse feeling'. The difference is one of priority: for Ayer, influence is an addition, as 'also' signals. For Stevenson, changing the hearer's interests is the judgement's object: 'your object isn't merely to let him know … You are attempting, rather, to get

him to disapprove of it.' Persuasion can also work through fear, however, so success in changing attitudes does not by itself justify a judgement.

In the second reading, 'disagreement in interest' concerns what people favour or oppose; a 'public dole' is state support for people in need. Facts settle such disagreement only when it is 'rooted in disagreement in belief', a dispute about facts. If A's sympathy and B's coldness survive full factual agreement, nothing further decides which attitude is correct. This is emotivism's link to relativism.

Questions for study

Comprehension *(AO1)*

1. Using Stevenson's first reading, explain why someone who knows that almost everyone disapproves of stealing may still not be convinced that it is wrong.
2. Using Stevenson's second reading, explain how the public dole example distinguishes disagreement in interest from disagreement in belief.

Analysis *(AO1 and AO2)*

1. Analyse 'I approve; do so as well' as an account of 'good', showing how each of its two parts relates to the view that ethical terms 'evince approval or disapproval'.
2. Analyse the step from the public dole example to 'relativism', identifying the premise needed to conclude that nothing decides which attitude is correct.

Synthesis *(AO1 and AO2)*

1. Synthesise Stevenson's account of disagreement in interest with the claim, in Topic 4, that people who differ in moral feeling do not contradict each other, showing in what sense they still disagree.

Evaluation *(AO2)*

1. Critically evaluate the claim that, because two people can agree on every fact and still disagree about whether something is good, 'good' has no 'objective factual basis'.
2. Critically evaluate the claim that, if ethical terms 'evince approval or disapproval' and urge attitudes on others, moral argument cannot be distinguished from manipulation.

Examination style essay *(AO1 16 marks and AO2 24 marks)*

‘Ethical terms do no more than “evince approval or disapproval”.’ Discuss. [40]

6 Hare and the logic of prescription

Introduction

Calling an action wrong seems to commit us to more than a feeling. R. M. Hare holds that moral judgements are prescriptions: like commands, they tell people what to do. They must also be universalisable: whoever makes one must make the same judgement about any relevantly similar case. The first reading comes from Hare's essay on slavery, where he states this rule. The second, from Miller, sets a logical test for theories, including Hare's, on which moral judgements do not simply state facts. Hare's prescriptivism is an extension: the specification names only naturalism, intuitionism and emotivism.

The text

R. M. Hare, 'What is Wrong with Slavery', Philosophy and Public Affairs 8 (1979), pp. 103–21; in Russ Shafer-Landau (ed.), Ethical Theory: An Anthology, 2nd edition (2013), pp. 463, 465.

> Utilitarianism, like any other theory of moral reasoning that gets anywhere near adequacy, consists of two parts, one formal and one substantial. The formal part is no more than a rephrasing of the requirement that moral prescriptions be universalizable; this has the consequence that equal interests of all are to be given equal weight in our reasoning: everybody to count for one and nobody for more than one. One should not expect such a formal requirement to generate, by itself, any substantial conclusions even about the actual world, let alone about all logically possible worlds. ... The wrongness of slavery, like the wrongness of anything else, has to be shown in the world as it actually is. We can do this by first reaching an understanding of the meaning of this and the other moral words, which brings with it certain rules of moral reasoning, as I have tried to show in other places. One of the most important of these rules is a formal requirement reflected in the Golden Rule: the requirement that what we say we ought to do to others we have to be able to say ought to be done to ourselves were we in precisely their situation with their interests.

Miller reading The embedding problem

Miller, Contemporary Metaethics (2013), §3.5, supplied PDF p. 85.

But now there is a problem in accounting for the following valid inference:

(8) Murder is wrong.

(9) If murder is wrong, then getting your little brother to murder people is wrong.

Therefore:

(10) Getting your little brother to murder people is wrong.

If the semantic function of 'Murder is wrong' as it occurs within an asserted context in (8) is different from its semantic function as it occurs within an unasserted context in (9), isn't someone arguing in this way simply guilty of equivocation? In order for the argument to be valid, the occurrence of 'murder is wrong' in (8) has to mean the same thing as the occurrence of 'murder is wrong' in (9).

Reading the argument

Hare treats moral judgements as prescriptions: like commands, they tell people what to do. They must also be 'universalizable': judging one person commits me to judging anyone relevantly similar alike. The Golden Rule expresses this: what we 'ought to do to others' must be what we can say 'ought to be done to ourselves' in their place. Excusing a friend's cheating but not a rival's fails it.

Being 'formal', the requirement yields no 'substantial conclusions' without facts about interests. Weakness of will, acting against one's own judgement of what one ought to do, is a difficulty: if judging 'I ought' commits me to acting, how can I sincerely judge so and not act?

Miller's reading sets out the Frege–Geach problem. The inference (8)–(10) has the valid form 'P; if P, then Q; therefore Q', but only if 'murder is wrong' means the same in (8) and (9). If its meaning lies in evincing disapproval, as emotivism holds, or in prescribing, as Hare holds, it cannot: in (9) it is unasserted, and someone who accepts (9) need not condemn murder. The argument would then equivocate, shifting a term's meaning. A non-cognitivist must explain why the inference is valid.

Questions for study

Comprehension *(AO1)*

1. Using Hare's extract, explain what Hare means by requiring moral prescriptions to be universalisable, and how the Golden Rule expresses that requirement.
2. Using Miller's reading, explain why 'murder is wrong' must mean the same in (8) and (9) if the inference is to be valid.

Analysis *(AO1 and AO2)*

1. Analyse what the validity of the inference from (8) and (9) to (10) shows about the sense in which 'murder is wrong' is 'meaningful'.
2. Analyse how far Hare's extract supports the view that the meaning of moral words is 'the defining question in the study of ethics'.

Synthesis *(AO1 and AO2)*

1. Synthesise Hare's account of moral judgements as universalisable prescriptions with Stevenson's account of their quasi-imperative force, showing what each allows moral reasoning to achieve.

Evaluation *(AO2)*

1. Critically evaluate the claim that the Frege–Geach problem refutes the view that ethical terms 'evince approval or disapproval'.
2. Critically evaluate the claim that, because moral judgements must be universalisable, they cannot 'reflect only what is in the mind of the person using such terms'.

Examination style essay *(AO1 16 marks and AO2 24 marks)*

> 'What is meant by the word "good" is the defining question in the study of ethics.'
> Discuss. [40]

Part IV Challenges to moral truth

7 Mackie and the challenge to moral realism

Introduction

Topic 3 asked how we could know basic moral truths. J. L. Mackie asks whether there are any to know. Moral realism holds that some moral judgements are true because there are objective moral facts. Mackie accepts that ordinary moral judgements claim such facts, but argues that none exist, so the claims are false. He calls this an 'error theory'. Unlike Ayer, he therefore treats moral judgements as meaningful but false, not as expressions of feeling. Two arguments support him: the argument from relativity and the argument from queerness.

The text

J. L. Mackie, Ethics: Inventing Right and Wrong (1977), 'The Subjectivity of Values', sections 'Moral Scepticism' and 'The Claim to Objectivity'; in Russ Shafer-Landau (ed.), Ethical Theory: An Anthology, 2nd edition (2013), pp. 22, 26.

> There are no objective values. ... I conclude, then, that ordinary moral judgements include a claim to objectivity, an assumption that there are objective values in just the sense in which I am concerned to deny this. And I do not think it is going too far to say that this assumption has been incorporated in the basic, conventional, meanings of moral terms. Any analysis of the meanings of moral terms which omits this claim to objective, intrinsic, prescriptivity is to that extent incomplete; and this is true of any non-cognitive analysis, any naturalist one, and any combination of the two. ... The claim to objectivity, however ingrained in our language and thought, is not self-validating. It can and should be questioned. But the denial of objective values will have to be put forward not as the result of an analytic approach, but as an 'error theory', a theory that although most people in making moral judgements implicitly claim, among other things, to be pointing to something objectively prescriptive, these claims are all false.

Mackie reading 2 The argument from queerness

Mackie, Ethics: Inventing Right and Wrong (1977), 'The Subjectivity of Values', section 'The Argument from Queerness'; in Shafer-Landau (ed.), Ethical Theory: An Anthology (2013), p. 28.

> Even more important, however, and certainly more generally applicable, is the argument from queerness. This has two parts, one metaphysical, the other epistemological. If there were objective values, then they would be entities or qualities or relations of a very strange sort, utterly different from anything else in the universe. Correspondingly, if we were aware of them, it would have to be by some special faculty of moral perception or intuition, utterly different from our ordinary ways of knowing everything else. These points were recognized by Moore when he spoke of non-natural qualities, and by the intuitionists in their talk about a 'faculty of moral intuition'. Intuitionism has long been out of favour, and it is indeed easy to point out its implausibilities. What is not so often stressed, but is more important, is that the central thesis of intuitionism is one to which any objectivist view of values is in the end committed: intuitionism merely makes unpalatably plain what other forms of objectivism wrap up.

Reading the argument

Mackie's argument has three steps. Ordinary moral judgements claim to point to 'something objectively prescriptive': a requirement to act that holds whatever anyone wants. But 'There are no objective values.' So these claims 'are all false'. Because the claim is built into the 'meanings of moral terms', the denial is an 'error theory', not an analysis of meaning. Note the scope: if 'Murder is wrong' is false, 'It is not the case that murder is wrong' is true. So the error concerns the claim to objective prescriptivity, not every sentence with a moral word.

The argument from queerness has 'two parts'. Metaphysically, objective values would be 'utterly different from anything else in the universe'. Epistemologically, knowing them would need 'some special faculty of moral perception or intuition'. Mackie names Moore's non-natural qualities (Topic 3).

The argument from relativity: varying moral codes are better explained as reflecting 'ways of life' than as distorted perceptions of objective values. Realists reply that basic principles are shared but differently applied; Mackie answers that this works 'only partly' (Mackie, p. 27). In the specification's terms, Mackie holds that moral judgements are 'true or false in describing something' but lack 'an objective factual basis': they are false, not meaningless.

Questions for study

Comprehension *(AO1)*

1. Using Mackie's first reading, explain how Mackie argues that ordinary moral judgements are in error, and why his denial of objective values cannot come from analysing the meanings of moral terms.
2. Using Mackie's second reading, explain the two parts of the argument from queerness and how each applies to Moore's non-natural qualities.

Analysis *(AO1 and AO2)*

1. Analyse why, if moral judgements are 'true or false in describing something', Mackie's conclusion that claims to objectivity 'are all false' must be limited in scope.
2. Analyse the epistemological part of the argument from queerness, identifying the unstated premise it needs to count against the view that basic moral truths are 'self-evident'.

Synthesis *(AO1 and AO2)*

1. Synthesise Moore's and Mackie's views of what objective goodness would have to be, showing why they agree about this but disagree about whether it exists.

Evaluation *(AO2)*

1. Critically evaluate the claim that naturalism, which holds that values can be 'defined in terms of some natural property in the world', escapes the argument from queerness.
2. Critically evaluate the view that, if there are no objective values, moral judgements are false rather than 'meaningless'.

Examination style essay *(AO1 16 marks and AO2 24 marks)*

To what extent can ethical terms such as good, bad, right and wrong be 'true or false in describing something'? [40]

Essay 1 Ethical meaning

Assess the view that good, bad, right and wrong are meaningless ethical terms. [40]

OCR H573/02 • June 2022 • Question 2 • Paper p. 2 • Open question paper

Argument 1 Cognitive meaning

Thesis

Ethical terms can have cognitive meaning even when their application and definitions remain contested.

↓

Argument in favour

Naturalism treats ethical judgements as claims about natural features. A hedonistic version identifies goodness with pleasure. Calling a policy good then invites investigation of its effects on pleasure and pain. Disagreement about the correct standard need not destroy meaning: speakers can understand a disputed claim without knowing whether it is true.

↓

Argument 2 Practical meaning

Thesis

Even without moral facts, ethical language remains meaningful through expression, persuasion and the guidance of choice.

↓

Argument in favour

Stevenson explains moral language through expressed attitudes and attempts to influence others. Condemning humiliation communicates opposition and seeks to change conduct. Evidence matters because correcting beliefs may alter attitudes. Moral discussion therefore has an intelligible purpose even if its distinctively ethical element does not state a moral fact.

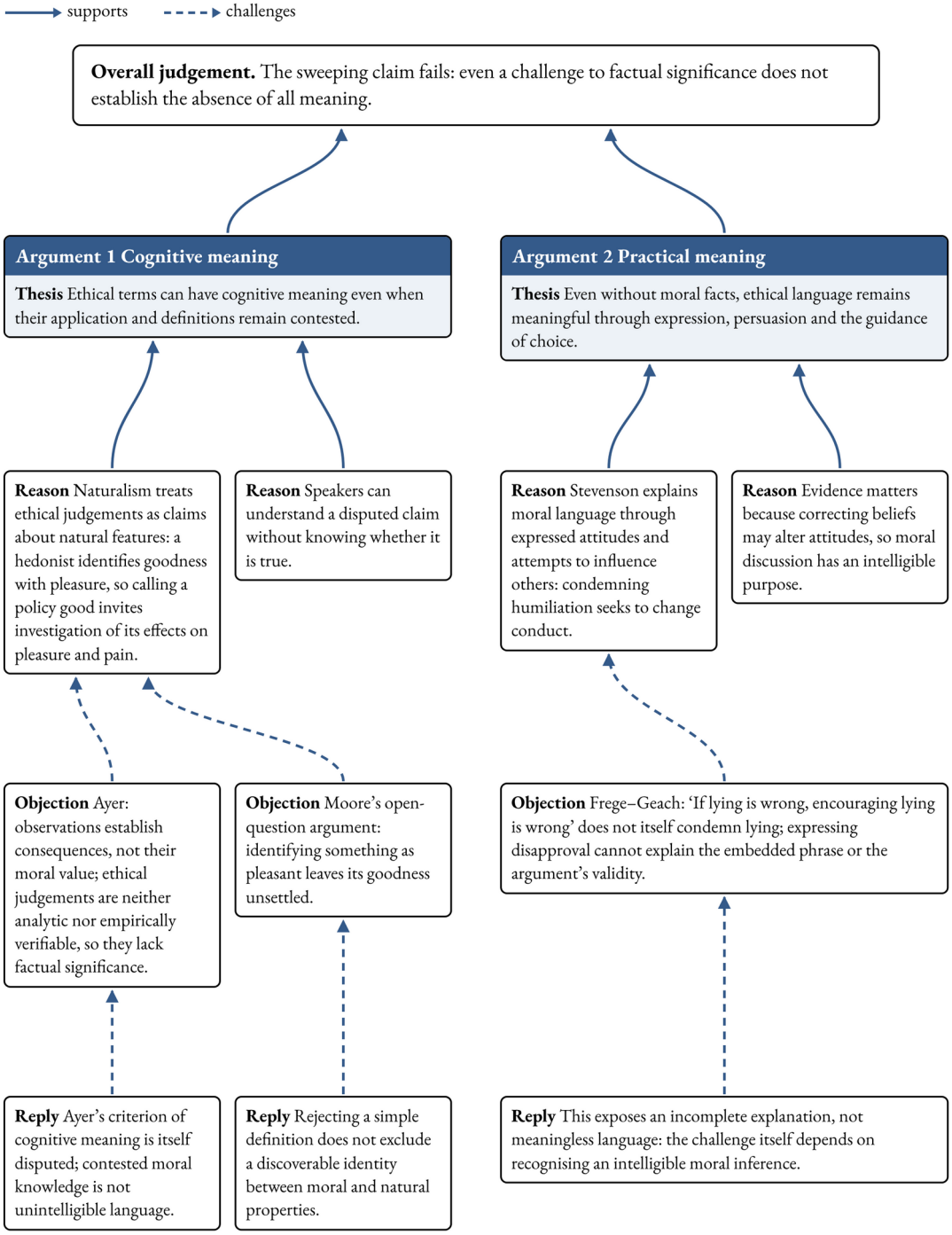
↓

Argument 1 Cognitive meaning	Argument 2 Practical meaning
Counter-argument Ayer objects that observations establish consequences, not their moral value. Ethical judgements are neither analytic nor empirically verifiable, so they lack factual significance. Moore's open-question argument adds a different challenge: identifying something as pleasant leaves its goodness unsettled.	**Counter-argument** The Frege–Geach challenge exposes a limitation: 'If lying is wrong, encouraging lying is wrong' does not itself condemn lying. An account based only on expressing disapproval struggles to explain the embedded phrase and the validity of arguments using it.
↓	↓
Counter-counter-argument Ayer's criterion of cognitive meaning is itself disputed. Moore's rejection of a simple definition does not exclude a discoverable identity between moral and natural properties. Naturalists must defend that identity, but uncertainty does not establish meaninglessness. Contested moral knowledge should not be confused with unintelligible language.	**Counter-counter-argument** This exposes an incomplete explanation, not meaningless language. The challenge itself depends on recognising an intelligible moral inference. Non-cognitivists still owe an account of that inference; cognitivists offer another. The dispute concerns how moral language means something. It does not show that moral language communicates nothing.

Overall judgement The sweeping claim fails: even a challenge to factual significance does not establish the absence of all meaning. State which sense of 'meaningless' your conclusion rejects.

Essay 1 Argument map

Assess the view that good, bad, right and wrong are meaningless ethical terms. [40]



Essay 2 Objective moral facts

'In meta-ethics, the term "good" has an objective factual basis.' Discuss. [40]

OCR H573/02 • June 2024 • Question 4 • Paper p. 3 • Open question paper

Argument 1 Natural facts

Thesis

Ethical hedonism offers a natural factual basis for goodness: pleasure. Its naturalist identification requires a defence, not just a definition.

↓

Argument in favour

A hedonistic naturalist identifies intrinsic goodness with pleasure and treats pain as intrinsically bad. Whether a policy increases happiness can be investigated independently of its popularity. Combined with a utilitarian criterion of right action, this supplies grounds for criticising harmful practices even when a community approves of them.

↓

Argument 2 Non-natural facts

Thesis

An objective factual basis need not be empirical: goodness could be a non-natural property.

↓

Argument in favour

Moore argues that goodness is a simple property, not a complex concept analysable into natural features. On a realist intuitionist account, some moral truths can be recognised through rational reflection without inference from observation. Their truth does not depend on approval, just as not every justified proposition is an empirical generalisation.

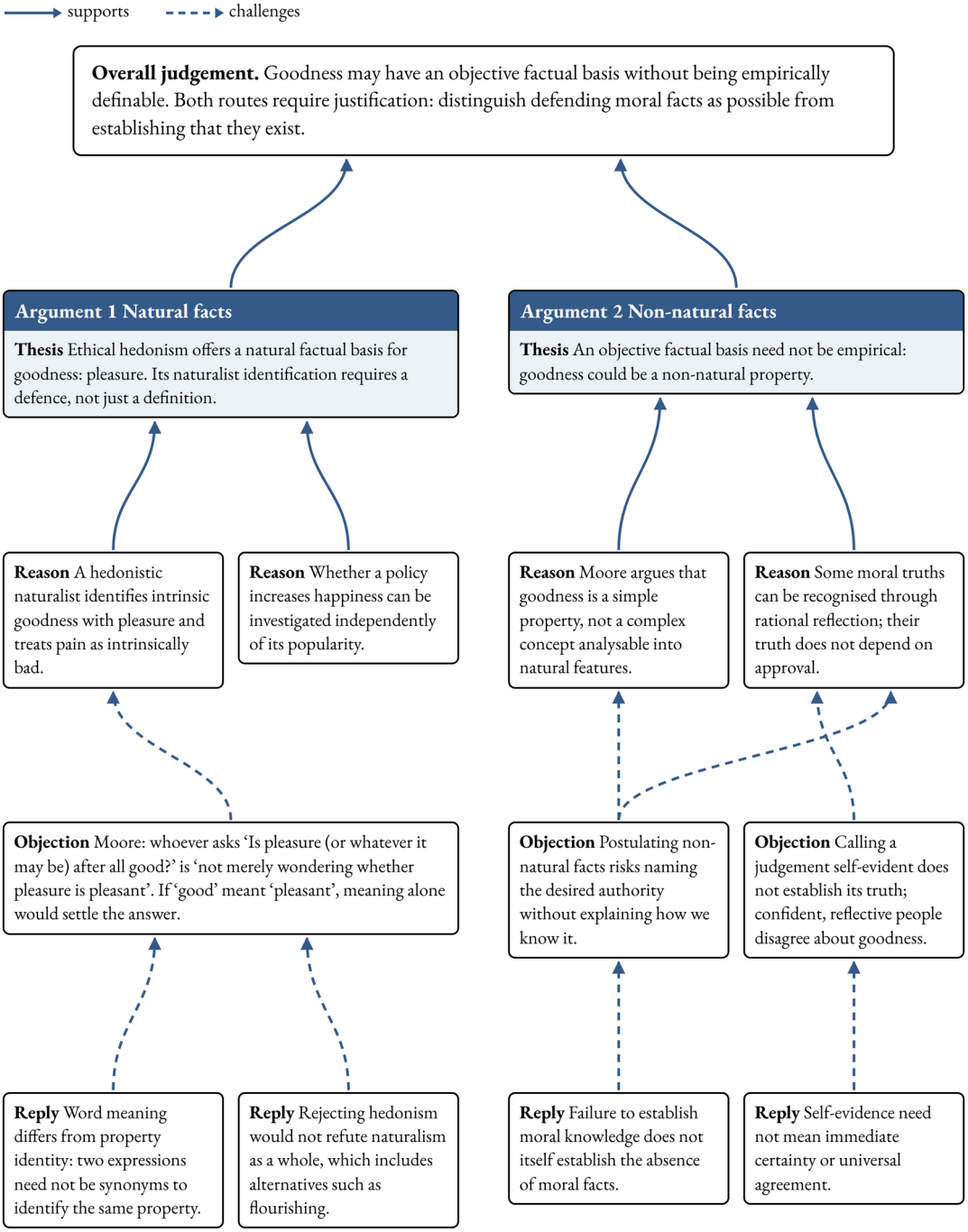
↓

Argument 1 Natural facts	Argument 2 Non-natural facts
Counter-argument Moore argues that whoever asks 'Is pleasure (or whatever it may be) after all good?' is 'not merely wondering whether pleasure is pleasant' (Moore, §13). The question remains intelligible for a competent speaker. If 'good' merely meant 'pleasant', the answer should be settled by meaning alone. The open-question argument therefore challenges the proposed definition of goodness as pleasure.	**Counter-argument** Calling a judgement self-evident does not establish its truth. Confident, reflective people disagree about goodness, and intuitionism struggles to distinguish rational insight from inherited prejudice. Postulating non-natural facts risks naming the desired authority without explaining how we know it.
↓	↓
Counter-counter-argument A naturalist can distinguish word meaning from property identity: two expressions need not be synonyms to identify the same property. The hedonist still owes a defence of pleasure's moral authority. Even if that defence fails, naturalism includes alternatives such as flourishing; rejecting hedonism would not refute the whole family.	**Counter-counter-argument** Self-evidence need not mean immediate certainty or universal agreement. An intuitionist distinguishes understanding a basic truth from judging its application, and demands consistency and reconsideration under objections. This answers crude appeals to feeling, although persistent disagreement still limits confidence. Failure to establish moral knowledge does not itself establish the absence of moral facts.

Overall judgement Goodness may have an objective factual basis without being empirically definable. Both routes require justification: distinguish defending moral facts as possible from establishing that they exist.

Essay 2 Argument map

'In meta-ethics, the term "good" has an objective factual basis.' Discuss. [40]



Essay 3 Self-evident goodness

To what extent is intuitionism correct in stating that good is self-evident? [40]

OCR H573/02 • June 2025 • Question 3 • Paper p. 3 • Open question paper

Argument 1 Indefinable good

Thesis

Intuitionism is largely correct. If 'good' cannot be defined, no basic truth about what is good can be proved from a definition of it, and any other proof would need a further truth about good as a premise. Such truths, if we know them at all, must be self-evident: evident by themselves, not inferred from other premises. Self-evidence is not the same as a strong feeling of certainty.

↓

Argument in favour

Moore argues that 'good' is 'a simple notion, just as "yellow" is a simple notion' (Moore, §7), so it has no definition. Hence 'propositions about the good are all of them synthetic and never analytic' (Moore, §6): none is true by definition, so none can be proved from one. Ross offers an example known directly: it is 'really self-evident, that virtue is good apart from its consequences' (Ross, p. 299).

Argument 2 Unexplained access

Thesis

Intuitionism is not correct. To call truths about good 'self-evident' names a way of knowing without explaining it. The variety of moral judgements is also better explained by the ways of life people share than by insight into an objective good. On this view, 'self-evident' is a label, not a justification.

↓

Argument in favour

Mackie argues that if we were aware of objective values, 'it would have to be by some special faculty of moral perception or intuition, utterly different from our ordinary ways of knowing everything else' (Mackie, p. 28). No ordinary account of knowledge fits, so 'a special sort of intuition' is 'a lame answer' (p. 28). Varying moral codes are better explained as reflecting 'ways of life' (p. 27).

Argument 1 Indefinable good

↓

Counter-argument

Ayer replies that 'what seems intuitively certain to one person may seem doubtful, or even false, to another'. Without 'some criterion by which one may decide between conflicting intuitions', an appeal to intuition is 'worthless', and for moral judgements 'no such criterion can be given' (Ayer, ch. 6). Calling a claim about good self-evident then settles nothing when people disagree.

↓

Counter-counter-argument

Intuitionists have a test: a conviction is rejected only when it conflicts 'with other convictions which stand better the test of reflection' (Ross, p. 761). Self-evidence concerns how a truth is justified, not whether everyone agrees. Ayer's demand also proves too much: if every belief needed a further criterion, that criterion would need another, without end. A critic can add that Ayer's verification principle seems to fail its own test.

Argument 2 Unexplained access

↓

Counter-argument

Intuitionists can look for 'companions in guilt' (Mackie, p. 28): truths about number, necessity and causation also resist a purely empirical account, yet we know some of them. They can add that societies share 'very general basic principles' and differ only in applying them to different circumstances (p. 27). Variation then concerns applications, not basic truths about good.

↓

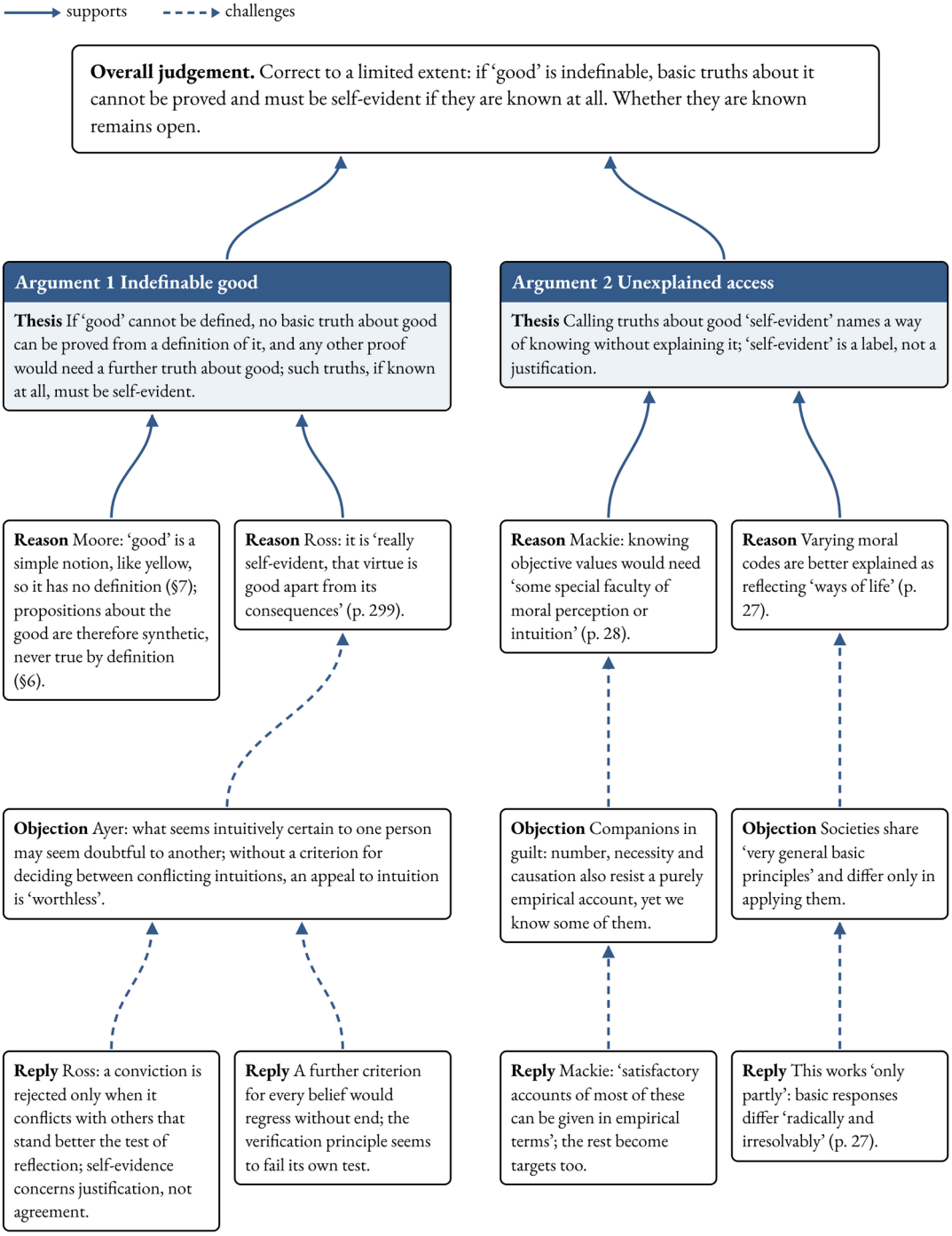
Counter-counter-argument

Mackie calls this 'an important counter' but believes that 'satisfactory accounts of most of these can be given in empirical terms'; any that cannot become targets too (p. 28). The principles reply works 'only partly': many basic judgements rest on immediate responses that differ 'radically and irresolvably', so for these 'starting points' the argument from relativity 'remains in full force' (p. 27).

Overall judgement Intuitionism is correct to a limited extent: if 'good' is indefinable, basic truths about it cannot be proved and must be self-evident if they are known at all. Whether they are known remains open, because intuitionists have not explained the faculty that grasps them, or why judgements about good vary with ways of life.

Essay 3 Argument map

To what extent is intuitionism correct in stating that good is self-evident? [40]



Essay 4 Explaining good

'Good is best explained by emotivism.' Discuss. [40]

OCR H573/02 • 12 October 2020 • Question 3 • Paper p. 2 • Open question paper

Argument 1 Value and approval

Thesis

Emotivism explains the force of approval, but this does not establish that 'good' lacks factual content.

↓

Argument in favour

A cognitivist can say that approval responds to a judgement of value rather than constituting its meaning. A hedonistic naturalist links value to pleasure and pain; evidence about a policy's effects can therefore bear on its assessment. This helps explain why moral speakers offer reasons as well as express feelings.

↓

Argument 2 Moral inference

Thesis

A successful explanation of 'good' must account for moral reasoning as well as emotional expression.

↓

Argument in favour

Consider: 'If helping is good, encouraging help is good; helping is good; therefore encouraging help is good.' The first premise does not independently praise helping. The Frege–Geach problem asks how the same evaluative phrase retains its meaning in both premises, so that the conclusion follows without equivocation.

↓

Argument 1 Value and approval	Argument 2 Moral inference
Counter-argument Ayer can reply that people may agree on every consequence yet disagree morally. The extra element is their attitude, not another observable fact. A hedonistic naturalist must also justify the move from a policy's increasing pleasure to its being good.	**Counter-argument** Stevenson allows facts to change attitudes and distinguishes persuasion from a mere emotional outburst. An emotivist might also try to explain the inference through consistent commitments. Moral argument could regulate attitudes without discovering a special moral property in the world.
↓	↓
Counter-counter-argument Persistent disagreement does not establish the absence of a fact: speakers may disagree about which account of value is correct. Naturalists must defend pleasure's value, or another natural basis, rather than assume it. Emotivism identifies a serious challenge but has not shown that approval exhausts the meaning of 'good'.	**Counter-counter-argument** An account of attitude change must still explain why accepting these premises while rejecting the conclusion is logically inconsistent, rather than merely unusual or unpersuasive. Simple emotivism has not supplied that account. This weakens its claim to be the best complete explanation, without proving that every non-cognitivist development must fail.

Overall judgement Emotivism illuminates moral motivation and persuasion. Its claim to explain 'good' best remains weaker where factual justification and valid inference still require explanation.

Essay 4 Argument map

'Good is best explained by emotivism.' Discuss. [40]

